CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

TOWER CLIMBER (TELECOM) IN THE AI ERA

Eleven thousand jobs, a thousand openings a year — and the beginner's first rung is the one the drones took.

★ **TL;DR — NO. BLS median $63,520 (Radio, Cellular & Tower Equipment Installers) — but that is the occupation, not the entry: first-year climbers land around $44–51K base, growth is +1% — +100 net jobs in a whole decade — and BLS itself calls the 5G buildout complete. The roadmap below is the way OUT, toward the work carrier money is actually rotating to.** ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

OUR TAKE: NO — NOT IN 2027

MEDIAN ~$64K · TRAINING 1-6 months · AI RISK LOW · CERTIFICATE

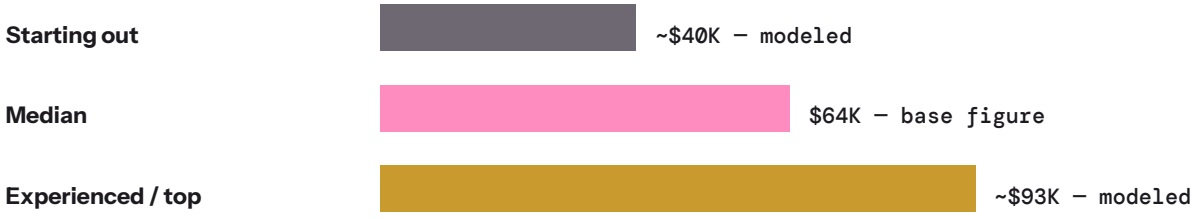
- Fails as a start because: this is the smallest occupation in the library — 11,300 jobs and ~1,000 openings a year nationwide (BLS). A beginner is not competing for a career ladder; he is queuing for a door that barely opens.

- The automation problem is surgically specific: drones now do tower inspections — NATE, the industry's own association, estimates inspection climbs cut by about a third. Inspection climbs were the beginner's rung. The surviving climbs — swaps, mods, new builds — are the experienced work he is not yet trusted with.

- The money rotated, it did not vanish: carriers are cutting radio spending and raising fiber spending (Dell'Oro), and the one carrier still spending up is spending it on fiber. The exit doors below follow the capex, not the nostalgia.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Tower Climber (telecom) is a ~$64K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A TOWER CLIMBER (TELECOM) ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Climb towers and rooftops to install, align and swap antennas, radios and cable
- ✓ Rig, hoist and secure equipment loads safely at height
- ✓ Inspect structures and document completed work with photos and closeouts
- ✓ Drive between sites across states, living out of hotels for stretches

Think: a construction worker whose scaffolding is the sky — in an occupation small enough to fit inside a mid-size town, whose easiest work just got outsourced to aircraft.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Drones with high-resolution and thermal cameras now inspect towers, measure antenna tilt, survey sites and shoot closeout documentation — for all three big tower owners and the carriers. Per NATE's own estimate, that removes about a third of inspection climbs.	Drones cannot turn a wrench at altitude. Swapping a radio, torquing a mount, rigging a load in wind — the physical work survives. It is also the work reserved for experienced, certified hands, which is exactly what a 2027 beginner is not.

⚠ **THE SMALL-DOOR PROBLEM: ~1,000 openings a year in the entire country, project-based crew work, and per diem that looks like salary until the build pauses and the crew is simply sent home. The $75K figure this title used to carry sits above the 90th percentile of what climbers actually earn.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ Views no office will ever match ✓ A brotherhood trade — crews bond hard at altitude ✓ Real, scarce skill for the climbers already certified and experienced	✗ Not growing: +1% for a decade, +100 net jobs (BLS) ✗ Not a beginner's market: the entry rung is the automated one ✗ Not home: weeks on the road is the default, in all weather

Good fit? Already a certified, experienced climber with top-hand hours. For you the trade is real and scarce — this map is not your exit notice, it is a warning to the class behind you.

Bad fit? A 2027 beginner buying a ticket into a 1,000-openings-a-year occupation whose first rung is being flown over — especially if the $75K headline is what sold you.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — PIVOT TO Fiber Optic Technician	DOOR B — PIVOT TO Elevator Mechanic
Same industry, same employers, same sites — on the ground. BLS median $74,330 with ~8,000 openings a year, and carrier capital is rotating from radio towers into fiber: this is where the money went. The aim matters more than the title: enter as a splicer — outside-plant and data-center fiber work — not as a raw residential drop installer, which is the shrinking corner. First move: the CFOT credential (days, not semesters), then contractor crews doing splicing and OSP builds.	The heights-and-mechanical cousin with a real license ladder: BLS median $109,910, growth +6% — the best-paid trade in this whole family. Read the rationing plainly: only ~1,900 openings a year and recruitment runs in slow, periodic windows through the union apprenticeship (NEIEP). It is a door you apply to early and wait for, not a door you walk through next month. First move: register interest with your local elevator constructors' apprenticeship and take mechanical/electrical prep work while your name climbs the list.

Smart move: If you climb anyway: get certified before you climb — Authorized Climber/Rescuer credentialing is required before a beginner may climb at all, not a nice-to-have — and aim every hour at the surviving work: installs, swaps, structural mods. Inspection-only experience is the depreciating asset.

Where you land after: You land where the buildout money went: splicing fiber that feeds the same towers, or riding a licensed ladder in a hoistway where no drone is coming. Either way your height comfort and field discipline were the transferable asset — the tower was just the wrong place to spend them.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
READ THE	PICK THE	TAKE THE	APPLY TO	OPEN THE	BUILD THE

STEP 1 — Read the size of the door

FREE · TODAY

- Check the arithmetic yourself: 11,300 jobs, ~1,000 openings a year, +100 net jobs in a decade (BLS).
- Decide that your field skills are the asset — and that they deserve a bigger market than this.

STEP 2 — Pick the fiber entry

FREE · 1 WEEK

- Map the fiber employers near you: OSP contractors, splicing crews, data-center build firms.
- Target splicing, outside-plant and data-center postings by name — skip raw drop-install listings.

STEP 3 — Take the CFOT

DAYS · LOW COST

- The Fiber Optic Association's CFOT is the basic certification for installation personnel — a short approved course plus exam.
- Add splicing-specific practice: fusion splicer, closures, OTDR basics. That bundle is what splicer postings ask for.

STEP 4 — Apply to crews that splice

PAID · WEEKS 3-8

- Apply to contractor splicing and OSP crews; the industry counts a ~178,000-worker gap, sharpest among splicers (FBA/PCCA).
- Your tower background sells here: heights, field discipline, closeout documentation, road tolerance.

STEP 5 — Open the elevator file in parallel

FREE · THIS MONTH

- Register with the elevator constructors' apprenticeship recruitment when your local opens its window.
- Log mechanical and electrical side-skills while you wait — the list rewards patience, not panic.

STEP 6 — Build the splicer résumé

PAID · MONTH 3+

- Count clean splices, closures built and tests passed — production proof is the splicer's currency.
- Stay out of the inspection-only corner: in fiber as on towers, the routine look-see is what machines eat.

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

□ Today: read the BLS numbers yourself — 11,300 jobs, +1% — then list the fiber contractors within driving range.

□ Days 1–30: CFOT course and exam booked or passed; first splicing practice hours logged.

□ Days 31–60: applying to splicing, OSP and data-center crews with the certificate in hand.

□ Days 61–90: on a fiber crew or in final hiring — and registered for the elevator apprenticeship window as your second door.

 Day 90: you are entering the segment the carriers are funding, not queuing at the smallest door in telecom.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ **FOLLOW THE GLASS.** ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.